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Making Online Forums Work for Community Networks

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This article was written for the inaugural issue of the *Association For Community Networking (AFCN) Newsletter*.

For additional Web Conferencing articles and resources, see the *Think of it Publications page*.

Online discussion forums have played a key role in community networks ever since the first such networks began to appear in the mid 1980's. Forums permit direct interaction among community members. They provide a place where local issues can be discussed and information can be shared quickly and easily.

The terms "forum" and "conference" are used to refer to a wide variety of things, ranging from chat rooms to real-time video conferencing. But this article will focus on text-based, asynchronous group discussions. Participants in such conferences can log in at their own convenience and read whatever messages have been posted since their last visit.

For a successful online forum, several elements are essential:

1. Clear purpose
2. Experienced hosts
3. Interested participants
4. Good software

Clear Purpose

The first step is to think carefully about why you want forums. Who do you expect to participate, and for what purposes? These questions are often glossed over as a community networking plan ("... and of course, we'll have a forum area...") but it's crucial to consider them. Unless your forums fulfill a clearly identifiable purpose, they are likely to languish.

People who simply enjoy online discussion for its own sake already have thousands of Web forums, Usenet newsgroups, and mailing lists to occupy their time. It's absolutely critical to define a specific purpose that distinguishes your conferences from all the others out there. You are most likely to succeed if your forums address the immediate, real-world needs of your constituency.

Start from a real problem or need, and then think about how (and whether) an online conference might fill the need.

Experienced Hosts

A forum host, or moderator, is someone who takes primary responsibility for the care and feeding of an online conference. The host sets the tone, establishes ground rules, initiates topics of discussion, encourages participation, and generally tries to ensure that the conference serves the purpose for which it is intended. This role is especially important in the early stages of conference building, as it takes a considerable amount

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